INTRODUCTION

Theory is considered to be a systematic reflection of phenomena, designed to explain them and to show how they are related to each other in a meaningful, intelligent pattern, instead of being merely random items of an incoherent universe. Theory is essential for every discipline to help in research and provide the basis for explanation and prediction. However, even the grand theories in social sciences, particularly in IR, have not provided with generalizations, principles or hypotheses with that force or vigour that they might be considered as the foundations for universally accepted comprehensive theories of IR. As we have seen in Chapter 1, the effort towards comprehensive theory-building in IR began with the first Grand Debate between the Idealists and the Realists. Subsequently in the 1940s, development towards theory-building was given a boost by growing interests in newer methodologies and techniques for research, analysis and teaching in IR. Further, the 1960s behavioural revolution opened up new avenues for research and methodological usage. Inputs were taken from biological, psychological, anthropological, sociological, economic and other behavioural sciences to explain international political behaviour. Contemporary IR is also witnessing a steady growth of several new approaches of the post-Positivist tradition. Despite such initiatives of theory building, Dougherty and Pfaltzgraff (Jr.)[1] point out that like all other social science disciplines, theory is more diffused and less precise in IR than found in the physical sciences. Till date, the mainstream IR discourse, however, is under the influence of three main theoretical perspectives on world politics—liberalism, political realism and world system theory. Of these again, political realism seems to have preponderance over the others.